

Comma Rules

How to use commas to increase sentence variety

Comma Rules

1

Use a comma plus a coordinating conjunction to join two independent clauses.

2

Use a comma to offset an introductory clause.

3

Use a comma to separate items in a list.

4

Use a comma on either side of an appositive.

Comma Rule

Use a coordinating conjunction paired with a comma to:

- join two independent clauses,
- to correct a run-on sentence,
- or to amend a comma splice.

These words have other functions as well and don't always need a comma.

Coordinating Conjunctions

Use the acronym FANBOYS to remember the coordinating conjunctions.

For **A**nd **N**or **B**ut **O**r **Y**et **S**o

Using Comma Rule

Place the coordinating conjunction after the comma when joining two independent clauses.

Independent clause, **coordinating conjunction** independent clause.

Bob eats, **and** Suzy sleeps.



Identify Comma Rule

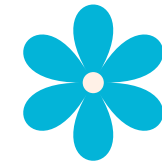
Which of the following examples are correctly using Comma Rule #1?

- ✿ I overslept, I missed the bus.
- ✿ Math class is difficult but I still love it.
- ✿ My notebook is messy, but I have a system.

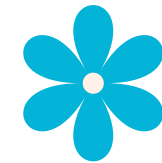


Apply **Comma Rule #1**

Correct the run-on sentences on the right and join them using Comma Rule #1.



I love tacos my dad does not.



It's snowing outside I want to go sledding.



I studied all night I feel ready for the test.

Comma Rule

Use a comma to offset an introductory clause

A subordinate clause can be used as an introductory clause. It begins with a subordinate conjunction and turns an independent clause into a dependent clause.

Common Subordinate Conjunctions

After

Until

Although

Because

As

Before

When

If

While

Since

Using Comma Rule

Place the comma after the dependent clause

Dependent clause, independent clause.

Although Bob likes cake, he didn't eat any today.

2

Identify Comma Rule

Which of the following examples are correctly using Comma Rule #2?



When the storm hit, we lost power for two hours.



After being lost for days the hikers were finally rescued.



Because the lane is closed ahead, traffic is slow.

2

Apply **Comma Rule**

Create a subordinate introductory clause and correctly place a comma in the following examples.



I go for a run I always feel more energized.



The show was canceled I have to find a new one to watch.



I finish my homework I can go to the mall.

Comma Rule

Use a comma to set off an interrupter that adds information to the sentence.

When a phrase interrupts to qualify a noun, it's called an appositive.

Appositives

Adds information to describe the thing it follows or precedes.

The information is not necessary to the sentence.

Usually a noun giving more description another noun.

Using Comma Rule

Place the commas on either side of the sentence interrupter. The appositive is unnecessary to the sentence, and the sentence should still make sense without it.

SENT, **interrupter**, ENCE.

Bob, **my neighbor**, loves to eat cheesecake.

3

Identify Comma Rule

Which of the following examples are correctly using Comma Rule #3?



Whiskers my cat loves to play with yarn.



My favorite city, Nashville, is full of live music.



Brian my cousin, is visiting this weekend.

3

Apply **Comma Rule**

Add an appositive to the following sentences.



The car raced down the street towards the store.



The puppy sprinted through the park after his toy.



Rachel was late for class.

Comma Rule

Use commas to separate items in a list or series.

The list can consist of three or more words, phrases, or clauses.

A comma can also be used to replace “and” between two adjectives of equal rank.

Using Comma Rule

Place the comma between each item in the a list, making sure the parallel structure is correct.

SENTE **N, C, and E.**

Bob eats **cupcakes, shortcakes, and whole cakes.**

Parallel Structure

Items in the list need to have equal grammatical rank.

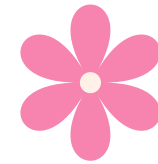
Correct: I went to the store, the library, and the park.

Incorrect: I went to the store, reading a book, and ran laps.

4

Identify Comma Rule

Which of the following examples are correctly using Comma Rule #4?



The sweet, crisp apple was the perfect snack.



My purse has my wallet, keys, and chap stick.

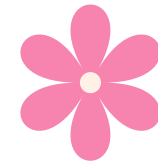


I ate bacon orange juice and waffles for breakfast.

4

Apply **Comma Rule**

Re-write each sentence
to correct the list and
comma usage.



Jane loves reading, to run,
and watches a movie.



The bright colorful room
lifted my mood.



The dog's loud incessant
barking kept the neighbors
awake all night.